

By **Yashwant Sinha**

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Weaponised Religion

The Indian Constitution, which had stood the test of time until now, is being destroyed by the very people who have sworn to uphold and protect it



Illustration by NILANJAN DAS

India is no stranger to communal strife. Ever since the British decided to follow the policy of divide and rule on the basis of religion, the country has been a witness to communal violence, even leading to its partition 75 years ago. Pakistan became a separate country on the basis of religion and, naturally, became an Islamic republic. But despite all the violence that preceded and accompanied Partition, India opted for a liberal, democratic and secular Constitution. And despite a large number of Muslims preferring to go to Pakistan (where they are still referred to as Muhajirs, a derogatory term), a larger number decided to stay on in India, hoping they would be safer and better off here. Yet the tension between the two communities continues to simmer and results in violence from time to time. But is what we are witnessing today part of the same pattern or is it different? In my view, it is vastly different. And it is so because of the role played by the government at the Centre and in the states ruled by the BJP. It is vastly different because the pursuit of political power has never been as devoid of values as today.

If the country today is drowning in an ocean of hate and being pushed deeper into it by these governments, it is not for the love of Hinduism, it is merely to obtain and retain power. The Sangh/ Sant Parivar is enjoying the situation like never before as they feel that their dream of a Hindu Rashtra is about to be realised. It has, therefore, weaponised religion to achieve its political goals. This is how the present rash of communal violence in the country is different from the earlier ones. Governments in the past may have failed to control communal riots, but today they are complicit in pro-